

Module OPSC6311: Part 1 (Research into Existing Budget Tracker Application)Student Number: **ST10345327**Name: **Olebogeng Phawe****TABLE OF CONTENTS**

1	Introduction.....	2
2	research	2
2.1	App 1: Wallet - Budget and Money Manager	2
2.1.1	Overview.....	2
2.1.2	Strengths and Weaknesses of Wallet	3
2.1.3	Innovative Features	4
2.2	App 2: YNAB (You Need A Budget).....	4
2.2.1	Overview.....	4
2.2.2	Strengths and Weaknesses of YNAB.....	6
2.2.3	Innovative Features	6
2.3	App 3: Money Manager by Realbyte Inc.	7
2.3.1	Overview.....	7
2.3.2	Strengths and Weaknesses of Money Manager.....	8
2.3.3	Innovative Features	9
3	Visual Comparison (Feature Infographic)	10
4	List of Features to Include in SaveSmart	11
5	Conclusion.....	12
6	References	13

Table of Figures

Figure 1: Home screen showing accounts and expense structure	3
Figure 2: Side navigation menu showing full feature list	3
Figure 3: Extended menu showing goals and settings	3
Figure 4: Onboarding emoji multiple-choice question screen	5
Figure 5: Home screen with guided setup checklist	5
Figure 6: Plan screen showing category budget list	5
Figure 7: Edit Plan screen showing monthly targets	5
Figure 8: Transactions screen showing day view	8
Figure 9: Accounts screen showing assets and liabilities	8
Figure 10: Settings screen showing backup and security options	8
Figure 11: Apps comparison infographic	10

1 INTRODUCTION

Keeping track of personal finances is one of the skills that many people find difficult to maintain consistently. Budgeting apps on mobile devices have made this easier by allowing users to record spending, set savings targets, and develop better financial habits. This research report investigates three top-rated budget tracking apps on the Google Play Store. **Wallet** by *BudgetBakers*, **YNAB** (You Need A Budget), and **Money Manager** by *Realbyte Inc.* I chose these apps because they each take a different approach to budgeting, providing a broad understanding of how these apps operate, what they do well, and where they fall short. A visual comparison is included to show how similar or different they are. The findings from this research will inform the design and development of a new Android budget tracking app called SaveSmart, built using Kotlin.

2 RESEARCH

2.1 APP 1: WALLET - BUDGET AND MONEY MANAGER

2.1.1 Overview

Wallet by BudgetBakers is an all-in-one personal finance app that helps users track expenses, manage budgets, and plan for their financial future. The app provides insightful reports and predictive alerts to help users stay within their budget limits. It supports automatic bank synchronisation and manual entry and is available on Android, iOS, and web. The app has a 4.6 star rating from more than 365 000 Google Play reviews and 10 million + downloads. It is known as one of the best free budget apps on Android due to its wide range of features and ease of use.

The following key features are documented by BudgetBakers (2026a; 2026b):

- **Automatic bank sync:** Connects to 15 000+ financial institutions worldwide (premium) or full manual entry (free)
- **Savings Goals:** Allows users to set a target amount and deadline with periodic saving calculations
- Google Drive backup, CSV and Excel export
- **Visual reports:** pie charts, bar graphs, and category breakdowns
- **Custom colour-coded Categories:** Including spending forecasts
- **Home screen widgets:** Let's user enter expenses without opening the app

WALLET: USER INTERFACE SCREENSHOTS

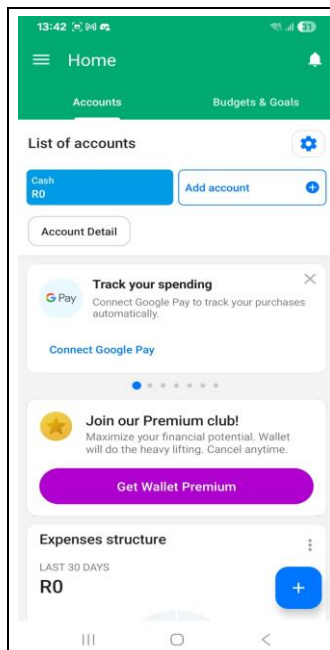


Figure 1: Home screen showing accounts and expense structure

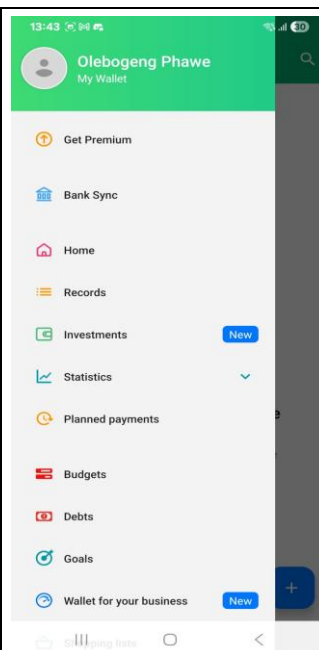


Figure 2: Side navigation menu showing full feature list

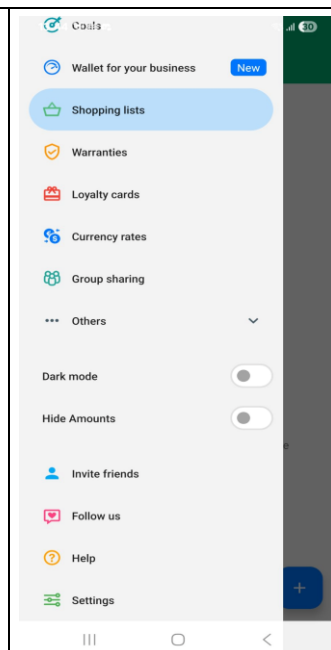


Figure 3: Extended menu showing goals and settings

2.1.2 Strengths and Weaknesses of Wallet

Strength	Weakness
Supports both automatic bank sync and fully manual entry	Bank sync feature is unreliable. Many users report it stops working after a few months with no fix provided (Google Play Store, 2026)
Savings Goals with visual progress tracking	Reports are locked behind the premium paywall, free users cannot view their own spending totals (Google Play Store, 2026)
Home screen widget allows fast entry without opening the app	Customer support response times are poor, multiple users report waiting weeks with no resolution (Google Play Store, 2026)
Google Play Editor's Choice with 4.6 stars from 365 000+ reviews	No gamification (no badges, points, streaks or reward system)
Free plan available with manual entry at no cost	Free plan is limited to three accounts

User feedback on the Google Play Store (2026) identifies three recurring complaints about Wallet: bank sync stops working reliably after a short period, spending reports are locked behind the premium paywall, and customer support response times are consistently slow. These limitations informed the decision to design **SaveSmart** as a fully offline app with no bank login required and all core features available for free.

2.1.3 Innovative Features

- **Home screen widget:** Lets users log an expense in seconds without opening the app
- **Savings Goals feature:** A progress bar fills as the user approaches a target, acting as a motivational tool for the user
- **Spending Forecasts:** The app predicts whether the user will stay within their budget limit based on their current spending rate (BudgetBakers, 2026b)
- **Stock/EFT Tracker:** Allows users to track which of their stocks performs the best
- **Customizable template:** Allows users to start with a customizable template for each category

2.2 APP 2: YNAB (YOU NEED A BUDGET)

2.2.1 Overview

YNAB (You Need A Budget) is a paid budgeting app that uses a zero-based budgeting method to help users gain control over their finances. Every rand or dollar earned is assigned to a spending category before it is spent. The app provides transaction entry and categorisation, real-time budget monitoring, and detailed reports and analytics. The user interface is user-friendly and intuitive with a clean minimalist design. **YNAB** is available on Android, iOS, and desktop/web, with real-time syncing to ensure budgets are always up to date. YNAB (2024) describes the app as the most effective tool for developing financial discipline. **YNAB** is the best app for users who want full control over their finances and are willing to paid for it. The app requires a subscription of approximately \$14.99 per month (approximately R252.02) after a 34-day free trial.

The following key features are documented by YNAB (2024):

- **Real-time sync:** Available across Android, iOS, and web
- **Zero-based budgeting:** Every unit of income assigned to a category before spending
- **Manual and bank-linked** transaction entry with real-time budget adjustment
- **Goal tracking per category:** spending limits, savings targets, and debt payoff goals
- **Detailed reports:** income vs. expenses, net worth, and spending trends over time
- **Free learning resources:** video workshops, podcasts, and live Q&A sessions

YNAB (You Need A Budget): User Interface Screenshots

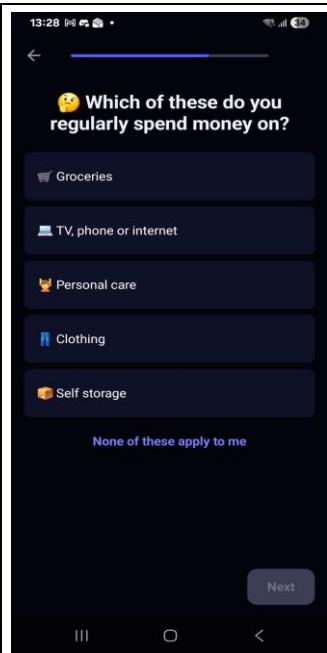


Figure 4: Onboarding emoji multiple-choice question screen

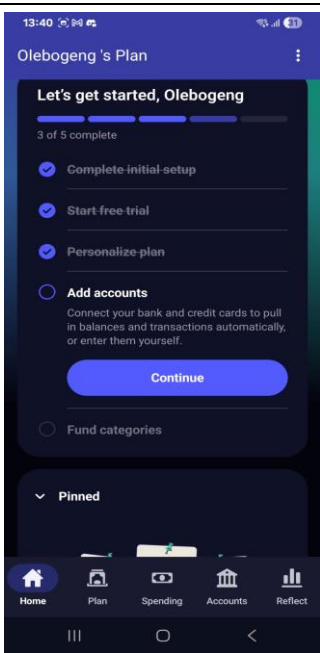


Figure 5: Home screen with guided setup checklist

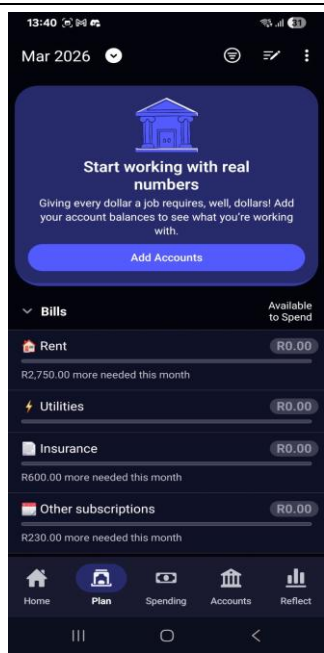


Figure 6: Plan screen showing category budget list

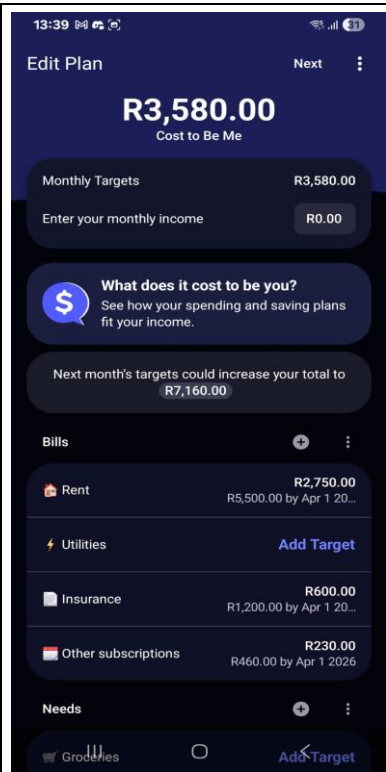


Figure 7: Edit Plan screen showing monthly targets

2.2.2 Strengths and Weaknesses of YNAB

<i>Strength</i>	<i>Weakness</i>
Zero-based budgeting builds real financial discipline	Bank sync not fully available in all countries, including South Africa
Strong goal-tracking with visual category progress indicators	No formal gamification system (no badges or points)
Interactive emoji-based onboarding makes setup easy for new users	Subscription cost is a barrier for many users, such as students
Free educational content builds long-term financial literacy	Steep learning curve, not easy for new users

2.2.3 Innovative Features

- **Interactive Onboarding Process:** **YNAB** asks simple questions with emoji-illustrated answers to personalise the setup experience. This feature makes the app feel approachable and significantly improves new user retention
- **"Cost to Be Me" Calculator:** A unique tool that helps users understand their personal baseline spending requirements and build a flexible financial plan around them (YNAB, 2024)
- **Shared Budgeting:** Allows up to six people to share one budget in real time under a single subscription, making it useful for families and couples (YNAB, 2024)
- **Loan Planner:** Calculates how much time and interest a user can save on debt repayment and tracks payoff progress, going beyond what standard budget apps typically offer (YNAB, 2024)
- **"Age of Money" Metric:** Shows the average number of days between earning and spending money, effectively gamifying financial patience and encouraging long-term savings habits (YNAB, 2024)

In addition, **YNAB** provides a public API (Application Programming Interface) at api.ynab.com/v1. YNAB API (2024) documents two technical decisions that are relevant to the app being built. First, all monetary amounts are stored as whole integers called milliunits, where 1 000 milliunits equals one unit of currency, to prevent floating point rounding errors. Second, categories are organised into named CategoryGroups for cleaner reporting. SaveSmart will inherit both technical patterns.

2.3 APP 3: MONEY MANAGER BY REALBYTE INC.

2.3.1 Overview

Money Manager is an Android finance application developed by Realbyte Inc. The app offers strong technical reliability with a user-friendly, visually clear interface. It is designed for everyday users who want quick insights into their finances without a complex setup. The app has more than 10 million + downloads, a 4.7-star rating from over 443 670 Google Play reviews and ranks seventh in the Finance category on Google Play (AppBrain, 2026). Realbyte Inc. (2026) states that the app uses a double-entry bookkeeping system, which is the same method used by professional accountants. The app is designed to work fully offline without any internet connection or bank account required. I would recommend it for users who want manual control over their finances without worrying about a recurring subscription every month.

The following key features are documented by Realbyte Inc.:

- **Expense tracking:** Easily record daily expenses and categorise them
- **Receipt photo attachment:** Photograph a receipt and attach it to any expense entry
- **Budget management:** Users can set budgets for different categories and monitor spending
- **Multi-device support:** Usable across multiple devices for continuity
- **PC web viewer:** Access and manage records on a desktop via Wi-Fi
- **Reports and analysis:** Aesthetical visual graphs and charts for clear spending insights
- **Premium option:** Ad-free experience available via one-time purchase

MONEY MANAGER: USER INTERFACE SCREENSHOTS

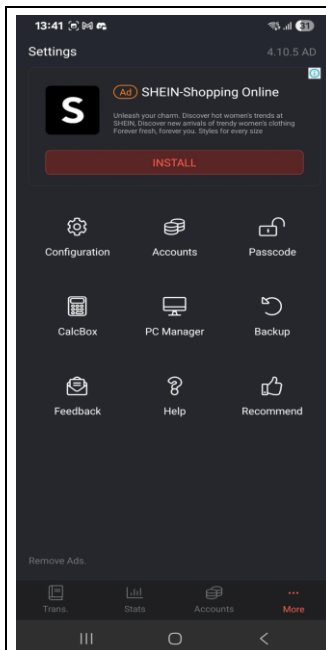


Figure 8: Transactions screen showing day view

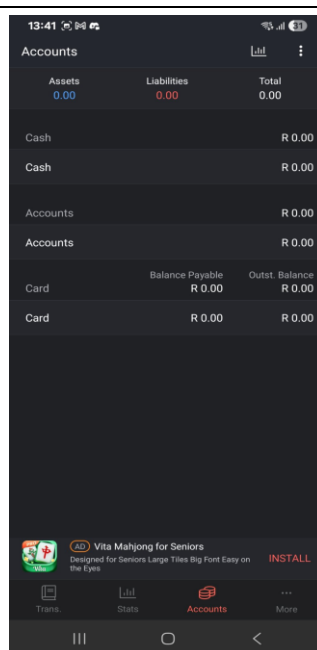


Figure 9: Accounts screen showing assets and liabilities

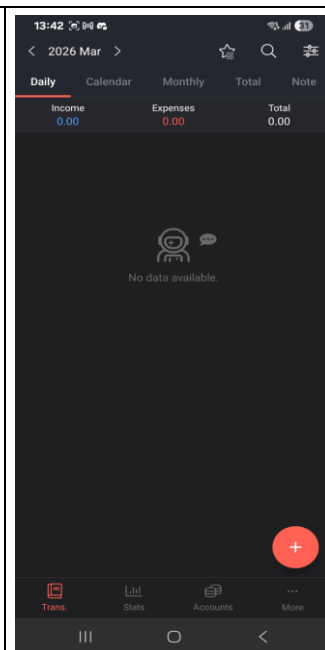


Figure 10: Settings screen showing backup and security options

2.3.2 Strengths and Weaknesses of Money Manager

Strengths	Weaknesses
One-time upgrade cost, not a recurring subscription	Free version contains ads, which interrupts user experience
Lightweight app with 10M+ downloads, indicating wide adoption and trust	User interface is dense and can overwhelm new users
Receipt photo attachment built into every expense entry screen	Double-entry bookkeeping system can confuse new users
Provides clear graphs, charts, and colour-coded categories for easy expense visualisation	Relies heavily on manual input. Offers less automation compared to apps with bank sync
It holds a 4.7-star rating and 443 670 reviews on Google Play	Privacy and Security Risks. In-app ads networks can be used to deliver malicious ads

2.3.3 Innovative Features

- **Native Receipt Photo Attachment:** *Money Manager*'s standout innovation is the ability to photograph a receipt and attach it directly to an expense entry without leaving the app. This is a free feature available for all users. Many competitor apps restrict such features to premium tiers.
- **PC Web Viewer:** *Money Manager* allows users to review and manage their full financial history through a desktop browser via a Wi-Fi connection. This is a unique feature which can't be found in *Wallet* or *YNAB*.
- **Play Pass Integration:** *Money Manager* offers premium access through Google Play Pass, making advanced features more affordable for existing Play Pass subscribers.
- **Multi-device Synchronisation:** The app supports usage across multiple devices, ensuring continuity and convenience without requiring a cloud account (Realbyte Inc., 2026).
- **Backup/Restore:** Users can make and view backup files in excel file and backup/restore is possible (Realbyte Inc., 2026)

3 VISUAL COMPARISON (FEATURE INFOGRAPHIC)

COMPARISON INFOGRAPHIC Wallet by BudgetBaker vs YNAB (You Need A Budget) vs Money Manager			
FEATURE	 WALLET	 YNAB	 MONEY MANAGER
USER LOGIN	✓	✓	✓ <i>PIN/passcode</i>
EXPENSE CATEGORIES	✓ <i>Custom + colour</i>	✓ <i>Manual</i>	✓ <i>+ subcategories</i>
ADD EXPENSE ENTRY	✓ <i>Manual + sync</i>	✓ <i>Manual / sync</i>	✓ <i>Manual only</i>
RECEIPT PHOTO	✗ <i>Not supported</i>	✗ <i>Not supported</i>	✓ <i>Built-in free</i>
BUDGET GOAL SETTING	✓ <i>Per category</i>	✓ <i>Zero-based</i>	✓ <i>Category limits</i>
SPENDING GRAPHS	✓ <i>Pie + bar</i>	✓ <i>Detailed</i>	✓ <i>Pie + bar</i>
PROGRESS DASHBOARD	✓ <i>Progress Dashboard Goals + bars</i>	✓ <i>Category view</i>	<i>Partial</i>
GAMIFICATION (BADGES/POINTS)	✗ <i>None</i>	<i>Partial (goals only)</i>	✗ <i>None</i>
FULLY OFFLINE	✓ <i>Manual mode</i>	<i>Partial</i>	✓ <i>Fully offline</i>
FREE TO USE	✓ <i>Freemium</i>	✗ <i>Subscription</i>	✓ <i>Free + upgrade</i>
Google Play Rating	4.5 ★ (365K reviews)	4.0 ★ (23K reviews)	4.7 ★ (433K reviews)

Figure 11: Apps comparison infographic

4 LIST OF FEATURES TO INCLUDE IN SAVESMART

1. **Full Gamification System (points, badges, leaderboard):** Gamification is human focused design. All three apps I researched don't offer a complete gamification system. Sebastian Deterding describes gamification as "the use of a game design elements in non-game context". Yu-kai Cou describes it better, "Gamification is the craft of deriving all the fun in games and applying the to real world or productive activities". **SaveSmart** will award points for daily expense logging, staying within category limits, and reaching monthly goals. Users will unlock milestone badges and compete on a leaderboard, making budgeting engaging and motivational.
2. **Receipt Photo Attachment:** **Money Manager** includes this feature as a free built-in function (Realbyte Inc., 2026). **Wallet** and **YNAB** doesn't support receipt photos. This feature can be help full for the user and will make the app much more will allow users to photograph a receipt using the device camera or select from the gallery and attach it to any expense entry at no cost.
3. **Offline-First Local Room Database:** Most features of **YNAB** requires the user to have internet access. **Wallet's** users are required to pay for the bank-sync feature. The only budget app that works offline is **Money Manager**. In the South African context, where data costs can be high, **SaveSmart** will store all data locally using a Room SQL/SQLite database, ensuring the app always works without an internet connection.
4. **Colour-Coded Budget Dashboard:** **Wallet** and **YNAB** use colour-coded indicators to help users understand their financial health visually. My app (**SaveSmart**) will use a progress dashboard with 3 colours for status labels per category, giving users an instant overview without needing to read detailed reports. This design is good for usability, readability and ensures clear communication.
5. **Milliunit Currency Storage:** YNAB API (2024) documents that all amounts are stored as Long integer milliunits, where 1 000 milliunits equals **R1.00**, for example **R12.50** is stored as **12 500**, to avoid floating point rounding errors. My app (SaveSmart) will use this same pattern in its Room database, converting to Rand display values only when rendering on screen.
6. **Interactive Onboarding Flow:** **YNAB's** emoji-based onboarding guides new users through setup using multiple-choice questions before they reach the main app. This feature improves new user retention. **Wallet** and **Money Manager** don't have a comparable first-run experience. My app (**SaveSmart**) will include a guided 3-step onboarding flow after registration.

5 CONCLUSION

This research examined three top-rated Android budget tracking apps available on the Google Play Store. **Wallet** by BudgetBakers, **YNAB**, and **Money Manager** by Realbyte Inc. Wallet is a flexible, well-designed app that suits a wide range of users and supports both bank sync and manual entry. **YNAB** is the most powerful tool for users who want complete financial control through zero-based budgeting (YNAB, 2024). Money Manager is the best option for fully offline manual tracking and is the only app to include receipt photo attachment as a free built-in feature. None provide a complete gamification system with points, badges, and a leaderboard. Analysis of the YNAB API (YNAB API, 2024) provided two additional technical insights, milliunit currency storage and category grouping both of which will be adopted in SaveSmart. The new app will combine the best features found in this research with a full gamification system that none of the researched apps currently provide.

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